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Religious Hypocrisy and Moral Failure in James Baldwin's *Go Tell It on the Mountain* and Khaled Hosseini's *The Kite Runner*

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ABSTRACT

This article explores how religious hypocrisy and moral failure are depicted in James Baldwin's *Go Tell It on the Mountain* and Khaled Hosseini's *The Kite Runner*, highlighting similarities and differences in their treatment of faith, power, and moral accountability across cultural contexts. Baldwin critiques Gabriel, a Pentecostal preacher whose actions contradict his moral authority, while Hosseini examines the Taliban's manipulation of faith to justify violence and oppression. Despite their differing historical and political settings – the racially segregated United States in Baldwin's mid-twentieth-century narrative and Afghanistan Taliban rule in Hosseini's – both authors reveal how religion can be exploited to legitimize societal control and mask personal shortcomings. Through the experiences of their protagonists, John Grimes and Amir, Baldwin and Hosseini demonstrate the destructive effects of such hypocrisy on individual identity . The narratives ultimately advocate resistance to oppressive systems, emphasizing moral growth, personal integrity, and the courage to challenge religious and social authorities.

Introduction

Religion has long served both as a source of moral guidance and a means of enforcing social control. In literature, its representation often highlights the tension between faith as a path to personal salvation and as a mechanism of manipulation. James Baldwin's semi-autobiographical novel *Go Tell It on the Mountain* (1953) and Khaled Hosseini's debut novel *The Kite Runner* (2003) vividly explore the hypocrisy and moral failures of religious figures and institutions, each set in distinct historical and cultural contexts. Both novels delve deeply into the complexities of faith, illustrating how religion is sometimes used to justify self-righteousness and conceal personal failings. The main characters in the narratives, John Grimes and Amir, respectively, grapple with internal and external conflicts stemming from the presence of hypocritical religious authorities in their lives. These contextual differences shape how Baldwin and Hosseini depict the personal and societal consequences of religious hypocrisy, as seen through the struggles of their protagonists.

In *Go Tell It on the Mountain*, John becomes increasingly aware of the contradictions and hypocritical nature of his stepfather, Gabriel, who serves as a preacher in a Pentecostal church. Gabriel uses his religious authority to enforce strict family rules and assert control over his wives, Deborah and Elizabeth, as well as his stepson, John. His violent treatment of his family and judgmental attitude starkly contradict the compassionate teachings of Christianity that he is supposed to embody as a godly man.

Similarly, Amir's journey in *The Kite Runner* exposes the hypocrisy of those who claim to uphold religious principles while using religion as a pretext to justify torture and victimize the marginalized and powerless. Characters like Assef, the novel's antagonist, and other Taliban officials claim to serve

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a divine purpose and use selective religious rhetoric to maintain power and commit acts of cruelty. However, their violent actions and racist ideologies, exemplified by the systemic execution of Hazaras – an ethnic group in Afghanistan that is predominantly Shia Muslim – starkly diverge from Islamic values of mercy and justice.

Despite their different cultural and historical contexts – Baldwin's novel focusing on the racial struggles that defined African American life in 1930s Harlem, and Hosseini's on the socio-political upheaval in Afghanistan from the 1970s to the 2000s – both novels offer reflections on individuals' struggles to find identity, faith, and redemption amidst societal oppression. Numerous critics have addressed the thematic concerns of these novels – such as father–son dynamics, sin and forgiveness, and racial and social inequality – but have often overlooked a joint analysis of both works.

Baldwin describes *Go Tell It on the Mountain* as an exploration of his complex relationship with his father and the church, mirroring John's conflict with his stepfather, Gabriel. This conflict highlights the emotional and psychological tensions experienced, as John, much like Baldwin, strives to reconcile love with a deep yearning for recognition. Baldwin reflects:

> *Go Tell It on the Mountain* was about my relationship to my father and to the church, which is the same thing really. It was an attempt to exorcise something, to find out what happened to my father, what happened to all of us, what had happened to me—to John—and how we were to move from one place to another. Of course it seems rather personal, but the book is not *about* John, the book is not *about* me. (qtd. in Brim 44, emphasis in original)

Baldwin's comparison between himself and his protagonist, John, suggests that while the narrative draws from his personal experiences, it transcends autobiography to tackle broader issues of faith and identity. This comparison underscores the powerful role of paternal authority and religious expectations in shaping identity, as well as the enduring emotional impact of unresolved familial conflicts. Similarly, Amir's relationship with Baba in *The Kite Runner* is defined by Amir's longing for his father's recognition, set against the cultural and societal fabric of Afghanistan. Wigati Prasasti and Putu Suarcaya emphasize "the conflicting views between Baba and Amir as father and son in viewing their new lives in the promised land of America" (57). They note, "As a father, Baba wants Amir to achieve what Baba did in Afghanistan where he had both wealth and respect from the Afghan people" (63). This underscores the generational divide between father and son, deeply rooted in a class of cultural values, as Baba expects Amir to achieve the material success and social status he once had in Afghanistan. Baba's view of success contrasts sharply with Amir's, who strives for a new life and new values in America, values completely different from the traditional ideals of Afghanistan.

In both novels, the father figures – Gabriel and Baba – symbolize broader societal and cultural ideals, particularly regarding authority and family expectations. The strictness of these powerful paternal authorities hinders the development of their sons' unique identities, as they prioritize cultural norms and societal traditions over personal autonomy.

Baldwin and Hosseini critique religious hypocrisy and moral failure by focusing on characters who exploit their religious authority to mask their ethical flaws. Gabriel in *Go Tell It on the Mountain* embodies religious hypocrisy through his authoritarian behavior, which directly contradicts Christian principles of compassion, mercy, and humility. Despite his position as a preacher, Gabriel's cruelty – marked by his judgmental nature and rigid treatment of his family – reveals how religious influence can be manipulated for personal gain. In *The Kite Runner*, Hosseini illustrates how characters like Assef and the Taliban weaponize religious principles to exert power and inflict brutality, exposing the divide between true faith and opportunistic exploitation.

This article argues that while Baldwin's *Go Tell It on the Mountain* and Hosseini's *The Kite Runner* both reveal the exploitation of religion to mask moral failure and consolidate power, they situate these dynamics within distinct historical, cultural, and political contexts. Baldwin exposes hypocrisy mainly within a U.S. Black Christian milieu, where patriarchal religious norms and systemic racial oppression shape individual conscience. In contrast, Hosseini portrays the politicization of religion in Afghanistan, where faith becomes a vehicle for power and moral control amid social upheaval. The comparison thus reveals not only shared mechanisms of religious hypocrisy but also crucial

differences in scope, institutional manifestation, and social consequence, underscoring how each author's context shapes the moral and societal dimensions of religious exploitation.

From Faith to Disillusionment: Baldwin and Hosseini on Religious Hypocrisy

Baldwin's and Hosseini's depictions of hypocritical religious figures and institutions are partly informed by their experiences and observations of how religion can be manipulated to reinforce societal control and justify moral failings. Baldwin's early life as a preacher in a Pentecostal church influenced his views on religion and its powerful role in shaping individual identities. He frequently addressed the pivotal role of religion in his writing, which Joseph Vogel describes as "a crucial vehicle through which his characters struggled, connected, explored, and evolved" (29). This underscores Baldwin's view of religion not merely as a system of beliefs but as a powerful force shaping characters' struggles with morality, identity, and societal conventions. The term "crucial vehicle" suggests that religion is central to the characters' development and transformation, guiding their journey of self-discovery and growth. Baldwin delves into the complexities of faith and its profound influence on individual and collective identity. He portrays religion as a catalyst for oppression or liberation, highlighting its multifaceted role in shaping human experience.

Baldwin's negative experience with the church shaped his critical view of religious institutions that failed to embody their professed ethical values. Joseph Vogel notes that Baldwin witnessed "greed, hypocrisy, and moral cowardice in his own Church" (36). These encounters profoundly influenced his writing, motivating him to expose the contradictions in religious practices and question the integrity of spiritual authority. This theme is evident in *Go Tell It on the Mountain*, where Baldwin highlights religious figures such as Gabriel, whose actions contradict their pious façades, reflecting his growing disillusionment with organized religion. In *The Fire Next Time*, Baldwin declares, "There was no love in the church" (50), a statement that marks his rejection of Pentecostal teachings. He further observes, "It [the church] was a mask for hatred and self-hatred and despair . . . When we were told to love everybody, I had thought that meant *everybody*. But no. It applied only to those who believed as we did, and it did not apply to white people at all" (50, emphasis in original). This powerful reflection underscores Baldwin's realization that the church fostered a selective and exclusionary faith rather than promoting universal love and acceptance.

The division between churches and the marginalization of the black church, of which Baldwin was a member, deepened his skepticism. It led him to conclude that religious figures are deeply flawed, showing how religious ideals can be weaponized to serve personal interests. The hypocrisy Baldwin witnessed in the church's insistence on an exclusive version of love represented a fundamental flaw, mirroring broader societal divisions. This reflects Baldwin's perception that the church functions not as a place of love and salvation but rather as a source of spiritual and moral oppression. As Baldwin argues in "Down at the Cross," "It is not too much to say that whoever wishes to become a truly moral human being . . . must first divorce himself from all the prohibitions, crimes, and hypocrisies of the Christian church. If the concept of God has any validity or any use, it can only be to make us larger, freer, and more loving" (314). This illustrates Baldwin's belief that genuine moral growth is impossible without rejecting the church's hypocritical teachings, which prioritize division over love and liberation.

The church's moral failings caused Baldwin to leave and abandon organized religion. As he explains in "To Crush the Serpent," "I did not want to become a liar. I did not want my love to become manipulation. I did not want my fear of my own desires to transform itself into power – into power, precisely, over those who feared and were therefore at the mercy of their own desires" (198). Baldwin's renunciation of Christianity stemmed not only from dissatisfaction with the church's practices but also from a desire to uphold his integrity and distance himself from its manipulative system.

The division between churches in Harlem, marked by deeply flawed religious figures, parallels the Pashtun-Hazara conflict in Afghanistan, which Khaled Hosseini experienced firsthand. This conflict reveals the longstanding rift between Sunni and Shi'a Muslims and highlights the moral failings of the

Taliban, who executed Hazaras in the name of Islam. Like Baldwin, Hosseini's early life was shaped by religious and cultural tensions, which were further intensified in Afghanistan by political turmoil and social violence.

The socio-political upheavals in Afghanistan profoundly shaped Hosseini's life. At age eleven, he and his family sought asylum in the United States following the Soviet invasion in 1979. Hosseini has noted that if his family had not fled Afghanistan, his father "would in all likelihood have been executed" under Soviet rule, and he himself "would have been forced into the army and sent off to fight" (qtd. in Tranter). This personal account underscores how political and religious turmoil in Afghanistan influenced Hosseini's life and deeply shaped *The Kite Runner*, particularly in its exploration of religious hypocrisy and the abuse of authority. Drawing heavily on his childhood memories, the novel depicts both the spiritual struggles and the brutality of the Taliban. Rachel Blumenthal observes, "It is, in fact, difficult to distinguish where *The Kite Runner* functions as autobiography (both Hosseini and the narrator are novelists and exiles from Afghanistan living in California) and where it functions as fiction" (262). The fusion of autobiography and fiction plays a crucial role in the novel's emotional impact, highlighting Hosseini's personal experiences with identity, exile, and religious hypocrisy.

Hosseini acknowledges that the experiences of his fictional protagonist, Amir, mirror his own privileged upbringing, one distanced from the traditional religious practices of Afghan society. Like Amir, Hosseini grew up in a relatively secular household where his father did not impose rigid religious rules on him or his siblings. This upbringing suggests a more liberal perspective, shaping Hosseini's secular worldview. He states, "I believe in a God. Come Ramadan I fast, and now and again I go to the mosque with my father" (qtd. in Young). Hosseini's personal beliefs, which do not align with the religious expectations of Afghan society, are reflected in Amir's complex relationship with faith in *The Kite Runner*.

In *The Kite Runner*, Hosseini reflects on the oppression faced by minority Hazaras at the hands of the majority Pashtuns, particularly under Taliban rule. Hosseini explores ethnic divisions through the complex relationship of Amir, a Pashtun, and Hassan, a Hazara. This emphasizes the role of religion in reinforcing social hierarchies, as religious differences deepen social rifts and perpetuate injustice. Spiritual authority is often exploited to legitimize violence and maintain Pashtun dominance over Hazaras. As a non-devout Muslim, Hosseini rejects strict ethnic or religious categorization, asserting, "I'm not pure anything. . . . There's a Pashtun part of me, a Tajik part of me" (qtd. in Tranter). By rejecting these societal and religious divisions, Hosseini critiques the use of religion or ethnicity to define individual identities, suggesting that these constructs often lead to systemic injustice and social unrest.

Hosseini condemns all forms of religious extremism, particularly those practiced by the Taliban, and highlights the devastating effects on minority groups. He voices his fear of the Taliban's return to power following the United States' withdrawal from Afghanistan in 2021, stating, "This is a group that for 20 years has systematically brutalized and terrorized Afghans, has blown up hospitals and roads and schools, and has slaughtered countless Afghans, many of them just ordinary villagers, women, and children as well" (Hosseini, "With the Taliban in Power"). This statement reflects his criticism of the Taliban's brutal history and their systematic violence against civilians, particularly women and children, and expresses his deep concern for the safety of the Afghan people under their rule. In *The Kite Runner*, violence and injustice experienced by Hazaras, like Hassan, reflect the real-life consequences of the Taliban's oppressive policies. The depiction of the Taliban's treatment of marginalized and vulnerable groups mirrors the extreme ideology they espouse in real life.

Hosseini reflects on criticism he received from some Afghan readers regarding the structural violence between Pashtuns and Hazaras depicted in *The Kite Runner*, saying, "They never say I am speaking about things that are untrue. Their beef is, 'Why do you have to talk about these things and embarrass us? Don't you love your country?'" (qtd. in Young). This reveals how uncomfortable some Afghans are with the portrayal of ethnic and religious divisions, particularly the divide between Pashtuns and Hazaras. Historically, Pashtuns, being the majority ethnic group, have enjoyed privilege and authority in Afghanistan, whereas Hazaras have endured marginalization and oppression. By

exposing these long-standing injustices, Hosseini prompts his fellow Afghans to confront uncomfortable truths about their society. The unity between Pashtuns and Hazaras, symbolized by the friendship of Amir and Sohrab at the end of the novel, represents the potential of religion to unify rather than divide.

Religious Power and Hypocrisy in Baldwin and Hosseini: A Foucauldian Analysis

Michel Foucault's assertion that "power is everywhere, not because it embraces everything, but because it comes from everywhere" (*Discipline and Punish* 93) illuminates how institutions, including religious ones, use power to maintain control through hypocritical practices and the distortion of truth. This concept resonates with Baldwin's critique of the church and Hosseini's condemnation of religious authority. Foucault's observation of the diffusion of power through religious discourse reveals how hypocrisy functions in both Baldwin's and Hosseini's works, even as the two authors write within very different historical, cultural, and political contexts.

Drawing on the social realities of mid-twentieth-century Harlem, Baldwin explores how the Black church serves both as a spiritual refuge and a reflection of social and racial inequality. His early life in a devout Pentecostal household and his brief experience as a teenage preacher profoundly shaped his understanding of religion as simultaneously empowering and repressive. Against the backdrop of segregation and the rise of the Civil Rights Movement, Baldwin critiques how Christian institutions became complicit in perpetuating patriarchal and racial hierarchies. He reflects on the constraints of his upbringing, noting, "Because I was born in a Christian culture, I never considered myself to be totally a free human being" (*The Price of the Ticket*, 436). Through the character of Gabriel – whose outward piety masks cruelty and self-righteousness – Baldwin exposes how religious authority could sustain oppression within family and community structures, mirroring broader social and moral conflicts. Thus, Baldwin grounds his criticism in the family, the church, and the community as sites where moral hypocrisy and systemic hierarchy intersect.

In contrast to Baldwin's Harlem-centered setting, Hosseini's narrative is deeply rooted in Afghanistan's modern political upheavals, spanning the collapse of the monarchy, the Soviet invasion, the civil war, and the rise of the Taliban. Hosseini portrays religion as a powerful instrument for enforcing political authority and social control, often intertwined with ethnic hierarchies. He reflects on his relative privilege in seeking refuge in the United States amid Afghanistan's turmoil: "When I go to Afghanistan, I realize I've been spared due to a random genetic lottery, by being born to people who had the means to get out. Every time I go to Afghanistan I am haunted by that" ("Shelf Awareness"). This remark underscores the historical and social realities that shape his narrative, particularly the systemic persecution of the Hazara minority, as embodied by the character of Hassan. Through Amir's quest for moral redemption, Hosseini exposes religious hypocrisy within institutional and national frameworks, in contrast to Baldwin's more localized critique of family and community. While both authors reveal how religion can be manipulated to enforce authority, they do so within distinct historical, cultural, and political settings, highlighting shared mechanisms of hypocrisy but differing in scope and societal impact.

In *Go Tell It on the Mountain*, Gabriel's authority as a preacher arises not only from his impassioned sermons but also from his manipulation of familial and social expectations. Similarly, in *The Kite Runner*, the Taliban's power stems from their control over cultural and religious discourses, which they exploit to shape every aspect of Afghan society. In both novels, religious figures and institutions assert power by embedding themselves within societal norms and beliefs, effectively masking their true influence. This pervasive power perpetuates religious hypocrisy, enabling authority figures to conceal their moral failings behind a façade of piety. Ultimately, this exposes how these power dynamics shape individual identities and sustain hierarchical structures within communities, all under the guise of spiritual guidance.

The success of religious institutions in maintaining power in Baldwin's and Hosseini's works depends on their ability to conceal hypocrisy behind a façade of righteousness. Gabriel's moral shortcomings – abuse, infidelity, and hypocrisy – along with the Taliban's oppressive agenda, including their enforcement of Pashtun supremacy over Hazaras, persist because they are shrouded in religious doctrine. This reflects Foucault's view that power's "success is proportional to its ability to hide its own mechanisms" (*History of Sexuality* 86). These oppressive practices allow power to appear legitimate and just while continuing to perpetuate systemic injustice. By exposing the hypocrisy of religious figures and institutions, Baldwin and Hosseini critique the weaponization of religion to reinforce social and moral hierarchies, urging readers to challenge these hidden structures of power.

Acts of defiance against oppressive power structures in both works embody Foucault's insight that "where there is power, there is resistance" (*History of Sexuality* 95). In *Go Tell It on the Mountain*, John's spiritual awakening on the church's threshing floor signifies a resistance born of moral and racial struggle, marking his rejection of Gabriel's authoritarian control and the church's moral hypocrisy. Similarly, in *The Kite Runner*, Hassan's unwavering dignity resists not only religious hypocrisy but also the ethnic and political violence sanctioned by the Taliban. His steadfastness in the face of brutality represents a quiet yet profound act of defiance against institutional oppression. These moments of resistance affirm Foucault's notion that power always engenders its own counter-force – manifested through "revolution, its promises, and its prophecies of future emancipation" (*Society Must Be Defended* 80). Both Baldwin and Hosseini thus illuminate the transformative potential of resistance, suggesting that exposing religious hypocrisy and rejecting coercive authority can lead to moral and social renewal.

The Church and Gabriel: Embodiments of Hypocrisy and Oppression In Go Tell it on the Mountain

Baldwin criticizes religious hypocrisy in *Go Tell It on the Mountain* through the character of the preacher Gabriel, emphasizing the stark contrast between his outward righteousness and private moral failings. Gabriel is described in the novel as "God's minister, the ambassador of the King of Heaven" (*Go Tell It* 17), who preaches salvation and godliness, yet his personal life is marred by abuse, infidelity, and dishonesty. Clarence Hardy notes that Baldwin's portrayal of Gabriel draws upon his "inside knowledge of how religious people think and act" (65). This insight underscores Baldwin's nuanced critique of organized religion, rooted in his experience as a preacher who left the church after witnessing its members' corrupt practices. Gabriel mirrors the religious figures Baldwin encountered in his life – those who display outward shows of holiness yet fail to adhere to the values they preach. Reflecting on his sinful past, Gabriel states, "Satan tempted me and I fell. I ain't the first man been made to fall" (*Go Tell It* 138), revealing his dual nature by rationalizing his wrongdoings as part of God's plan for his salvation. This self-justification highlights the dissonance between his actions and the values he claims to uphold.

Gabriel's hypocritical nature is further revealed in his violent treatment of his family, particularly his wife, Elizabeth, and his two sons, John and Roy. He portrays himself as a patriarch who demands obedience and reverence, yet his actions starkly undermine his moral authority. As a preacher, Gabriel is obligated to embody values of love, discipline, and kindness, but instead turns to manipulation and abuse to control his family. He asserts dominance over his wife by "[slapping] her across the face" (*Go Tell It* 47), and when Roy defends his mother, Gabriel reacts brutally: "Then his father [Gabriel] raised his belt, and it fell with a whistling sound on Roy, who shivered, and fell back, his face to the wall" (48). These acts of violence unmask Gabriel's hypocrisy by revealing his failure to follow the spiritual and moral principles he preaches. Instead of fostering a household grounded in love and compassion, Gabriel enforces fear and suffering, justifying his abusive behavior through his roles as preacher and patriarch.

Baldwin portrays the church as the source of Gabriel's divine power, elevating him to a spiritual leader with unquestioned authority over his congregation. Gabriel's character is driven by a thirst for

power and divine validation, evident in his reflections: "Yes, he wanted power – he wanted to know himself to be the Lord's anointed, His well-beloved . . . He wanted to be master, to speak with that authority which could only come from God" (*Go Tell It* 97). This reveals Gabriel's obsession with dominance and self-righteousness, which he uses to conceal his sins. In addition, his fiery sermons instill fear and guilt in the congregation by stressing humanity's inherent sinfulness and the consequences of moral failure, thereby reinforcing his authority as a preacher. He proclaims: "For let us remember that the wages of sin is death; that it is written, and cannot fail, the soul that sinneth, it shall die. Let us remember that we are born in sin . . . sin reigns in all our members" (108). While Gabriel's rhetoric emphasizes human weakness and the inevitability of sin, his extramarital affair with Esther and his illegitimate child stand in stark contrast to his teachings, allowing him to maintain a façade of moral superiority.

John's experience within the church exposes the oppressive influence of Gabriel's authority, as he struggles with guilt and inadequacy. Dennis Knight observes, "The fear that permeates John's thoughts and actions comes from Gabriel's position within the community and the family" (136). This fear stems not only from Gabriel's authoritative control but also from the congregation's broader complicity. The congregation's blind faith and unquestioning obedience perpetuate religious hypocrisy. Father James defends the severity and harsh treatment of religious figures, claiming, "Let them [congregation members] remember that God would ask an accounting of him [the preacher] one day for every soul in his flock . . . that the Word was hard, that the way of holiness was a hard way" (*Go Tell It* 13). Yet this justification merely conceals the abuse of power, sustains fear, and blocks genuine spiritual growth.

Baldwin critiques Gabriel's racial attitudes, emphasizing how his harsh condemnation of white people contradicts the Christian core values of love, compassion, and forgiveness. Gabriel's perspective on the inherent wickedness of white people is evident in the declaration: "His father [Gabriel] said that all white people were wicked, and that God was going to bring them low" (*Go Tell It* 34). This highlights his tendency to moralize and make sweeping generalizations. However, his stance frequently leads to overblown and misguided judgments, as seen in his responses to racial conflicts. When Roy gets involved in a fight with white boys, Gabriel states, "You can tell him [Roy] to take this like a warning from the Lord" (45). Aunt Florence counters sharply: "Why, Gabriel, it ain't him [Roy] went half-way across this city to get in a fight with white boys . . . I declare, I do wonder what goes on in your head" (45), exposing Gabriel's avoidance of accountability and oversimplification of complex situations. Knight relates Gabriel's harsh judgments and attempts to assert dominance to his feelings of inferiority to white people, observing, "Gabriel compensates for his lack of authority and equality with white men by oppressing those whom he feels are inferior to himself" (145), perpetuating the cycle of moral hypocrisy and oppression.

Gabriel's mistreatment of women is deeply influenced by his distorted interpretation of religious doctrine, which he uses to legitimize his abuse under the pretext of divine righteousness. His belief in male dominance is justified by biblical passages such as Ephesians 5:22–23 in the *King James Bible*: "Wives, submit yourselves unto your own husbands, as unto the Lord. For the husband is the head of the wife, even as Christ is the head of the church: and he is the savior of the body." He manipulates these teachings to maintain control over women, presenting himself as the spiritual leader while overlooking their suffering and autonomy. Gabriel exploits his religious authority to assert control over Deborah, Elizabeth, and Esther, viewing them as subordinates meant to serve him and fulfill his needs. He views his first wife, "Deborah [and his second wife Elizabeth] as instrumental, a childbearing vessel" (Nenon 15), reducing them to mere property while disregarding their individuality and trauma. Similarly, with Esther, his hypocrisy is evident after engaging in an affair with her and later dismissing her with the cruel remark: "I got God's work to do – my life don't belong to you. Nor to that baby, neither – if it is my baby" (*Go Tell It* 138). Esther's retort, "I ain't the first girl's been ruined by a holy man" (138), exposes the destructive consequences of weaponizing religion to mask personal flaws. Through these interactions, Baldwin critiques the manipulation of religious teachings to maintain patriarchal control and justify the victimization of women.

The Mullahs and the Taliban: Embodiments of Hypocrisy and Oppression in *The Kite Runner*

Amir's experience with hypocritical religious teachers and the Taliban in Hosseini's *The Kite Runner* parallels John's experience with Gabriel and the church in Baldwin's *Go Tell It on the Mountain*. At school, Amir's teacher, Mullah Fatiullah Khan, a "stubby man with a face full of acne scars and a gruff voice" (*The Kite Runner* 17), teaches about the rigid prohibitions in Islam, condemning actions like drinking and warning that sinners will be held accountable on Judgment Day. Amir recalls, "He [the Mullah] told us one day that Islam considered drinking a terrible sin; those who drank would answer for their sin on the day of *Qiyamat*, Judgment Day" (17). The Mullah's unappealing appearance and harsh tone convey emotional coldness, deepening Amir's disillusionment with those who manipulate religion to impose rigid doctrines devoid of compassion. This moral strictness, especially in its endorsement of discrimination against marginalized groups like the Hazaras, reduces religion to a mere set of rules rather than a source of ethical guidance.

Amir's awareness of religious hypocrisy and societal oppression grows as he learns about the historical persecution of the Hazara community in Afghanistan, including violence and exploitation. He states, "The book said that my people had killed the Hazaras, driven them from their lands, burned their homes, and sold their women" (*The Kite Runner* 10). This moment forces Amir to confront the complicity of the Pashtun majority in perpetuating systemic injustice, revealing the stark contrast between true religious values and the corrupt practices of those in power. The rise of the Taliban exemplifies the exploitation of Islam to justify their authoritarian control, with the strict enforcement of a distorted version of Islamic law. Public executions and severe punishments for minor offenses highlight how the Taliban use religion as a tool to instill fear and maintain dominance. These acts of violence deepen Amir's understanding of how religion is stripped of its spiritual essence and twisted to uphold authoritarian rule under a false appearance of piety.

Baba, Amir's father, embodies the tension between outward religious devotion and secular humanism, revealing the hypocrisy within Afghan society. His genuine kindness and moral integrity contrast sharply with the intolerance and rigidity of religious figures like the Mullah, who are supposed to provide spiritual guidance. Amir reflects on Baba's secular attitudes, stating, "Baba had been such an unusual Afghan father, a liberal who had lived by his own rules, a maverick who had disregarded or embraced societal customs as he had seen fit" (*The Kite Runner* 195). This description highlights Baba's rejection of blind conformity to societal norms, as he prioritizes universal principles of humanity and justice. Baba's adherence to these values is exemplified when, during his escape from Afghanistan amidst the violence that followed the Soviet invasion, he courageously intervenes to save an Afghan woman from being assaulted by a Russian officer, declaring, "Tell him [the Russian officer] I'll take a thousand of his bullets before I let this indecency take place" (126). Through this act, Baba demonstrates that goodness and virtue are not solely dependent on religious piety, challenging the belief that faith alone defines righteousness.

The suffering of the Hazara and Shi'a servant Hassan, and later his son Sohrab, at the hands of Sunni Pashtuns throughout the novel reflects the harsh realities endured by religious minorities in Afghanistan. Alla Ivanchikova's description of Hassan's face as resembling "a sacrificial lamb" (203) and his "unwavering loyalty" (*The Kite Runner* 96) to the Pashtun Amir stand in stark contrast to the deep-rooted discriminatory attitudes of the majority of Pashtuns. Despite experiencing prejudice and abuse, Hassan's loyalty becomes a poignant symbol of innocence and virtue, intensified by the cruelty of his oppressors. This contrast emphasizes Hosseini's "desire to overcome or elude partisan, ethnic, religious and national divisions" (Aubry 26) and his critique of how virtue and kindness are often obscured by these divisions. Hassan's selflessness challenges the assumption that one's worth is determined by religious or ethnic background, suggesting that morality transcends these boundaries. Additionally, Hosseini's portrayal of the friendship between Amir and Hassan embodies his hope for unity, illustrating how genuine friendship and moral integrity can flourish despite societal divides.

The novel's antagonist, Asef, who becomes a Taliban commander following the rise of the Taliban to power, represents the oppressive attitudes of the Pashtun majority against the Hazara minority. David Jefferess describes Assef as "the archetype of the sinister and the cruel" (393), whose "well-earned reputation for savagery preceded him on the streets" (*The Kite Runner* 43). Assef's belief in Pashtun supremacy and his disdain for Hazaras are vividly illustrated when he declares, "Afghanistan is the land of Pashtuns . . . His people [Hazaras] pollute our homeland, our watan. They dirty our blood" (43–44). These sentiments foreshadow the Taliban atrocities, including the "massacre of 2500–3000 Hazaras in 1998 at Mazar-i-Sharif and Sheberghan" (Jefferess 391). Assef's brutality contrasts with the innocence and purity of Hassan, whom he assaults in a horrific act of violence that symbolizes the larger societal injustices perpetuated by the Taliban regime. Through Assef's character, Hosseini suggests that his cruelty and dehumanization of Hassan are emboldened by the immunity and privilege granted to individuals under an authoritarian regime. This protection not only shields Assef from accountability but also strengthens his belief in the righteousness of his actions, turning him into a symbol of institutionalized injustice and unchecked authority in Afghan society.

Assef represents the profound hypocrisy of the Taliban regime by presenting himself as devout and righteous while maintaining a life of luxury and sadism. Zohreh Ramin and Ilham Ward note that "the Taliban is currently the most powerful extremist/fundamentalist Islamic group" (29), attempting to enforce a distorted "version of Shari'a" (*The Kite Runner* 250). The cleric's announcement before stoning a woman for adultery – "We are here today to carry out Shari'a. We are here today to carry out justice" (292) – starkly contrasts with the pervasive injustice of the regime. This includes violent acts such as the shooting of Hassan and his wife, Farzana, based on false accusations that they were unlawfully occupying Baba's house. Shockingly, their "murders were dismissed as a case of self-defense" (237). The tragic death of Hassan and his wife symbolizes the loss of innocence and justice in Afghanistan at the hands of corrupt individuals like Assef, who inflict suffering on others while enjoying a comfortable life.

Assef openly boasts about his family's luxurious lifestyle in Western Australia:

> Have you ever heard of Rockingham? Western Australia, a slice of heaven. You should see it, miles and miles of beach. Green water, blue skies. My parents live there, in a beachfront villa. There's a golf course behind the villa and a little lake. Father plays golf every day. Mother, she prefers tennis . . . They own an Afghan restaurant and two jewelry stores; both businesses are doing spectacularly. (304)

This sharp disparity between Assef's lavish lifestyle and the Taliban's rhetoric of justice and piety underscores the hypocrisy of those who exploit extremist ideologies for personal gain. Assef's moral corruption is further exemplified by his exploitation of children from the orphanage. Zaman, the orphanage director, reveals, "He [Assef] visits once every month or two. He brings cash with him, not a lot, but better than nothing at all . . . Usually he'll take a girl. But not always" (277). This shocking predatory behavior illustrates how Assef weaponizes religious authority to prey on vulnerable and innocent members of society. Moreover, Zaman's confession, "If I deny him one child, he takes ten" (278), further highlights the climate of terror imposed on the powerless. Assef's heinous actions reflect the broader moral corruption of the Taliban, where piety is merely a façade for exploitation and unchecked authority.

The Taliban's brutal treatment of women, along with their exploitation of children, epitomizes the dehumanizing extremes of their ideology. This regime's treatment of women as mere property and their forced obedience are normalized under the pretense of enforcing divine law. Farid, Amir's friend and companion in rescuing Sohrab after his abduction from the orphanage, recounts a disturbing incident where Mullah Nasruddin beats his daughter after she seeks refuge from her abusive husband: "Agha, did you hear what Mullah Nasruddin did when his daughter came home and complained that her husband had beaten her?" (*The Kite Runner* 288). The response, "He beat her too, then sent her back to tell the husband that Mullah was no fool" (288), shows how domestic abuse is tolerated by the regime. Additionally, the public execution of an adulterer is justified as God's will, with the cleric claiming, "Every sinner must be

punished in a manner befitting his sin!" (292). This chilling declaration emphasizes how the Taliban's twisted interpretations of religious principles leave women helpless and unprotected. Moreover, the crowd's participation in the stoning of the woman illustrates the success of institutionalizing violence against women. Hosseini's reflection on the profound moral failure of the Taliban regime, which led to Afghanistan's descent into chaos, suggests that challenging such a regime is a national duty.

Confronting Religious Hypocrisy: A Journey Toward Justice and Freedom

Both Baldwin and Hosseini suggest throughout their novels that challenging religious hypocrisy is integral to achieving both personal identity and social liberation. John's rejection of Gabriel's authority and his spiritual awakening at the end of *Go Tell It on the Mountain* emphasize the importance of confronting oppressive power structures. As Miller Wilbourn states, "John finds himself under the power of Gabriel's determinist religion, then challenges and overcomes it" (133), signifying his autonomy from the restrictive beliefs imposed by his stepfather. Roy's bitter sarcasm further highlights his dissatisfaction with the religious constraints imposed on his family: "We so lucky to have a father who just wants us to go to church and read the Bible and beller like a fool in front of the altar and stay home all nice and quiet, like a little mouse" (21). These harsh words reflect Roy's disillusionment with a religious system that values conformity and submission over genuine spiritual growth.

Florence, Gabriel's sister, also rejects her brother's role as a preacher and relentlessly attempts to dismantle his influence. She asserts, "He [Gabriel] ain't got no right to be a preacher. He ain't no better'n nobody else. In fact, he ain't no better than a murderer" (*Go Tell It* 91). The equation of Gabriel as a murderer is especially poignant, given his role in the deaths of Esther, his illegitimate son Royal, and Deborah. This underscores the consequences of unchecked authority and the importance of holding religious figures accountable for their actions. In a letter Esther sends to Gabriel before she dies while giving birth to her son Royal, she challenges his oppressive rituals, stating, "*And I ain't going to read to him [Royal] out of no Bibles and I ain't going to take him to hear no preaching*" (142, emphasis in original). Esther's refusal to follow Gabriel underscores her rejection of his beliefs and the need for religious reform. As the characters become aware of the contradictions between Gabriel's teachings and actions, they reach a turning point and begin to question his authority.

In *The Kite Runner*, Hosseini explores the clash between genuine integrity and moral failure through both individual defiance and societal critique. Baba challenges the authority of religious figures, openly accusing the mullahs of being hypocritical and narrow-minded. He expresses his disdain, telling Amir, "You'll never learn anything of value from those bearded idiots" (18). This sharp critique underscores Baba's rejection of their teachings as shallow and lacking genuine moral guidance. Baba's view of the mullahs aligns with the novel's broader commentary on the failures and contradictions of those who exploit religion for self-interest rather than using it to promote justice and compassion.

Hosseini's critique of religious hypocrisy is further emphasized in Sohrab's courageous confrontation with Assef, a character who embodies moral corruption masked by self-righteousness. Sohrab's heroic act of blinding Assef with his slingshot not only protects Amir but also symbolizes a rejection of the brutality and moral decay Assef represents. His plea to Assef, "No more, Agha. Please . . . Stop hurting him [Amir]" (*The Kite Runner* 313), highlights his resistance to both Assef's violent actions and the false moral superiority he claims. The moment when Sohrab strikes Assef, leaving him grievously injured and screaming "the cries of a wounded animal" (314), symbolizes the dismantling of oppressive power structures and the triumph of personal integrity over corrupt systems that perpetuate injustice and cruelty. In this way, Hosseini draws a parallel between Baba's skepticism of religious hypocrisy and Sohrab's unwavering moral clarity, reinforcing the necessity of confronting oppressive forces to achieve justice and freedom.

Conclusion

The interplay between religious hypocrisy and moral failure in Baldwin's *Go Tell It on the Mountain* and Hosseini's *The Kite Runner* underscores the ongoing human struggles with questions of faith, justice, and identity. Both Baldwin and Hosseini use their protagonists, John and Amir, respectively, to expose the exploitation of religious authority by figures who manipulate spiritual principles to mask their moral flaws and perpetuate social inequities. Baldwin's portrayal of Gabriel's tyranny and harsh authority contrasts with the Christian ideals of compassion and humility, while paralleling Hosseini's depiction of the Taliban's inhumane practices, which distort Islamic teachings of peace and mercy. Through these depictions, the authors encourage readers to challenge the manipulation of religion as a tool for oppression and to critically examine the agendas of those who exploit faith – whether within the U.S. Black Christian context of Baldwin or the politically turbulent Afghan context of Hosseini.

At the core of these narratives lies a shared exploration of the necessity of resisting oppressive power structures that seek to suppress autonomy and integrity. John's spiritual awakening represents a clear rejection of Gabriel's rigid authority, while Sohrab's act of defiance against the Taliban official Assef exemplifies the courage to stand against cruelty and injustice.

Both characters show that resisting tyranny – whether within the family or society – prompts significant moral growth and self-discovery. Baldwin and Hosseini further reveal how John's and Amir's struggles with oppressive authority highlight the conflict between cultural expectations and personal identity. Their ultimate defiance challenges the established norms that perpetuate hypocrisy and moral corruption, affirming individual rights and ethical principles.

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